

the no paint refresh

The Domain Comes Home

Hosting swap, a living archive of 32,184 paintings, and the road to the .ART Award

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<https://nopaint.art> · [grants/dot-art-award-2026/](https://grants.dot-art-award-2026/)

1. SUMMARY

No Paint — the collaborative painting game that preceded Aesthetic.Computer — moved from Vercel onto AC's own production monolith (lith) today, with its preserved 2021 build serving at the root and at /classic, valid TLS, and a new endless gallery over its full painting archive at /gallery. Along the way the archive turned out to be far larger and far more alive than expected, the game's save server turned out to be dead, and lith's TLS layer taught a lesson worth writing down. The work anchors the entry for the **.ART Award 2026** (\$15,000 grand prize, deadline November 1): *No Paint, 2016–present*, an artwork that is literally a domain.

2. WHAT SHIPPED

- **done Hosting swap.** The complete 2021 Construct export (165 files: runtime, 32 spritesheets, all 130 audio files, fonts, icons) was mirrored from the live Vercel deployment into `system/public/nopaint.art/` and now serves from lith. DNS A records for the apex and `www` flipped from Vercel (76.76.21.21) to lith (209.38.133.33) via `doctl`; the zone was already in DigitalOcean.
- **done Source recovery.** The editable Construct project (`No Paint.c3p`, 7.4 MB) was pulled from Dropbox and its SHA-256 matches the provenance hash recorded in the migration plan. It is extracted locally — 45 event sheets, 82 layouts, 205 object types, 1,197 images — so brush ports need neither Dropbox nor Construct.
- **done Gallery.** <https://nopaint.art/gallery> — an endless grid over every painting in the archive, with by-year filters and a shuffle view, images served straight from the existing `pix.nopaint.art` CDN, styled in the game's own Pixelar face and `#ebebeb` grey. Driven by a generated 1.4 MB manifest (408 KB gzipped).
- **done Valid TLS.** Let's Encrypt production certificate, `CN=nopaint.art`, valid through October 17, plus a separate certificate for `www`, which 301s to the apex.

3. THE ARCHIVE IS ALIVE

The project file suggested a finished 2021 artwork. The bucket says otherwise: **32,184 paintings, 3.9 GB**, each 256×288 pixels, uploaded continuously for four years after “Summer 2021.”

Year	Paintings kept
2021	15,407
2022	8,016
2023	5,449
2024	2,112
2025	1,200

People kept pressing Paint for four years after the artwork was “done.”

The taper to zero is not fading interest — it is infrastructure death. The game saves through `server.nopaint.art`, a CNAME to `glitch.edgeapp.net`, and Glitch no longer exists. **dead** Saving is broken today; restoring it (a small lith endpoint writing into the same DigitalOcean Space, plus a CNAME repoint) would bring the archive back to life. One loss to flag: the paintings carry no painter-handle metadata — no PNG text chunks, no S3 metadata — so attribution, if it was ever recorded, lived in the dead Glitch app. Worth checking for a Glitch project export before declaring it lost.

4. THE TLS POST-MORTEM

The swap's only real fight was TLS, and the loud symptom was a decoy. Three problems stacked:

1. **DNS timing.** Caddy's first ACME attempts fired before the flip propagated, so validation reached the old Vercel IP.
2. **Staging demotion.** After those failures Caddy demoted the host to Let's Encrypt's *staging* endpoint, whose resolvers held the stale IP for up to the record's one-hour TTL, and its retry backoff stretched to tens of minutes.
3. **The real bug: certificates were obtained but never served.** lith's Caddyfile is one big `:443` catch-all that pins its certificate selection to the Cloudflare origin certificate. The Caddyfile adapter emitted *only* that catch-all TLS connection policy — so every SNI, including `nopaint.art`, was handed the origin certificate even after issuance succeeded. `www` held a valid certificate for hours without serving it. The proof and the fix both came from `caddy adapt`: adding a distinct per-site TLS setting (`protocols tls1.2 tls1.3`) forces an SNI-matched policy with managed-certificate selection, ordered ahead of the catch-all.

The recipe is documented in the Caddyfile itself and in agent memory: any future direct-DNS (non-Cloudflare)

domain on lith needs the same per-site TLS block, and caddy adapt | jq verifies the policy order before deploying.

5. THE AWARD FRAME

The .ART Award 2026 (<https://award.art>) is uncannily aligned: the submission *is* a .art domain URL. Grand prize \$15,000 cash, plus month-long residencies in France and Spain, editorial coverage, and a premium .art domain; deadline November 1, winners December 3; no fee, no geographic restriction, multiple entries allowed. The jury includes Jerry Saltz and Regina Harsanyi (Museum of the Moving Image), whose specialty is variable-media and software preservation — exactly what this project practices: a hash-verified source recovery, a preserved classic build at a stable URL, and a living native remake at the same address.

The entry: No Paint, 2016--present --- an artwork that is a domain, submitted as the domain itself.

Materials live in `grants/dot-art-award-2026/` (research + draft bio, process narrative, documentation plan), with a tracker row on the papers deadlines page. An optional second entry — cancelok, on the free-as-of-July `nopad.art` — gets decided by mid-October only if it matures.

6. WHAT'S NEXT

In order, toward November 1:

1. **open Restore saving.** Lith endpoint → `pix.nopaint.art` Space; repoint the dead `server` CNAME; regenerate the gallery manifest on save. The classic game becomes fully alive for the first time since 2025.
2. **open Native remake at the root.** The proposal loop already landed in `Aesthetic.Computer` (`disks/nopaint.mjs`, explicit choosing/proposing/committing states plus the original weighted picker and a test suite). The root page presents it; the classic build stays at `/classic`.
3. **open Port the authored brushes** from the extracted event sheets — Softy, Bubbles, Grid Worm, Walker, Banner, Wafer first — treating each sheet as a behavioral score, not code to translate.
4. **open The story page** (`/story`): 2016 → Summer 2021 → the quiet four years → `Aesthetic.Computer` → the remake.
5. **open Submit:** trim bio and narrative to the form, cut the 30–60s process video, verify collection claims, decide the credit line (solo vs. the 2021 collaborators), file well before the deadline.

pressed together from the July 19 session ·
Aesthetic.Computer · the archive does not end here